



Japan and failed to start on the right note.

Japan had lost its last three matches against India but on January 19, when it mattered, it played a tactically solid game — using the aerial balls to break the Indian press and forcing the opponents to go for inconsequential runs on the flank.

Kana Urata scored the all-important goal in the sixth minute and then, the Japanese defence, despite conceding nine penalties, stood like a wall. Coached by former Indian goalkeeper Jude Menezes, Japan eventually shut the door to the Olympics for India.

The campaign is a crushing blow after the high of the fourth-place finish at Tokyo Olympics three years ago and leaves plenty of questions to be answered.

What does the future hold for coach Schopman now? Hockey India president Dilip Tirkey told *Sportstar* that the federation has no major

concerns about the 46-year-old Dutchwoman but will look at the plans and talk to everyone concerned.

**Where is India's next batch of drag flickers and players it can rely on when it comes to converting penalties in clutch situations?** While the likes of Deepika and Udita did impress, whether they can succeed experienced players such as Gurjit Kaur and Katariya remains to be seen.

Is it time for the players to get some exposure from playing league hockey abroad? The likes of Dhanraj Pillay and Tirkey have done it. Playing

**The road ahead:** While the likes of Deepika (55) and Udita did impress, whether they can succeed experienced players such as Gurjit Kaur and Katariya remains to be seen. PTI

as an overseas player in such tournaments brings another level of pressure and expectations that can be useful at the international level.

The new Olympic cycle for India starts with the FIH Pro League matches in February and the preparation for Los Angeles 2028 needs to start as quickly as possible.

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